

HOUSE No. 2516

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

Orlando Ramos

To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act establishing an advisory committee on the accessibility of fresh food retail in communities throughout the Commonwealth.

PETITION OF:

NAME:	DISTRICT/ADDRESS:	DATE ADDED:
<i>Orlando Ramos</i>	<i>9th Hampden</i>	<i>1/13/2025</i>
<i>Jacob R. Oliveira</i>	<i>Hampden, Hampshire and Worcester</i>	<i>2/10/2025</i>
<i>James C. Arena-DeRosa</i>	<i>8th Middlesex</i>	<i>4/24/2025</i>
<i>James B. Eldridge</i>	<i>Middlesex and Worcester</i>	<i>6/17/2025</i>
<i>Natalie M. Higgins</i>	<i>4th Worcester</i>	<i>9/16/2025</i>

HOUSE No. 2516

By Representative Ramos of Springfield, a petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 2516) of Orlando Ramos and Jacob R. Oliveira relative to establishing an advisory committee (including members of the General Court) on the accessibility of fresh food retail in communities. Public Health.

[SIMILAR MATTER FILED IN PREVIOUS SESSION
SEE HOUSE, NO. 3632 OF 2023-2024.]

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act establishing an advisory committee on the accessibility of fresh food retail in communities throughout the Commonwealth.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. (a) There shall be an advisory committee to examine the accessibility of
2 fresh food retail in communities throughout the commonwealth. The advisory committee shall:
3 (i) develop criteria to determine which communities lack adequate access to fresh food retail,
4 particularly urban and rural communities; (ii) investigate the causes of inadequate access to fresh
5 food retail; (iii) study the public health impact of inadequate access to fresh food retail; (iv)
6 develop innovative strategies and recommendations to increase access to fresh food retail,
7 including: legislation, economic incentives and financing options, improvements to
8 transportation, public-private partnerships, pilot programs and the improvement of food
9 programs already in existence; and (v) calculate the costs and potential savings of all strategies

and recommendations and determine the benefits, drawbacks and feasibility of all strategies and recommendations.

(b) The advisory committee shall consist of: (i) the commissioner of public health, or a designee, who shall serve as chair of the advisory committee; (ii) the secretary of housing and economic development, or a designee; (iii) the commissioner of agricultural resources, or a designee; (iv) the chairs of the joint committee on public health; (v) a nutritionist appointed by the commissioner of public health; and (vi) 5 members to be appointed by the governor, 1 of whom shall be a representative of the supermarket industry, 1 of whom shall be a representative of farmers markets, 1 of whom shall be a representative of the gateway cities, 1 of whom shall be a representative of nonprofit and not-for-profit hunger relief organizations and 1 of whom shall be a representative of the Massachusetts Public Health Association.

(c) The advisory committee shall commence no later than 90 days after the effective date of this act.

(d) The advisory committee shall file a report with its findings, recommendations and draft legislation to the senate and house committees on ways and means, the chairs of the joint committee on community development and small business, the chairs of the joint committee on public health and the chairs of the joint committee on children, families and persons with disabilities no later than 18 months after enactment of this section.

SECTION 2. The advisory committee shall expire upon submission of the report pursuant to subsection (d) of section 1.